



SCATTER THE OLD WORLD, BUILD THE NEW

THE CULTURAL REVOLUTION (1966)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Maoism to capitalism

BEFORE

1943 Mao becomes Chairman of the Communist Party of China, which bolsters his image as a “strong leader.”

1945–1949 A civil war between Communists and Nationalists ends with Mao’s victory.

1958–1961 Millions die during Mao’s Great Leap Forward, his attempt to modernize China.

AFTER

1972 US President Richard Nixon’s trip to China paves the way for diplomatic relations between the two countries.

1978 Deng Xiaoping becomes new leader and starts economic reforms.

2015 The IMF ranks China as the world’s largest economy, overtaking the United States.

The Cultural Revolution was one of the darkest periods in Chinese history. Since taking power in 1949, Communist Party leader Mao Zedong had neither created his ideal China nor secured his power. To bolster his primacy and ignite revolutionary fervor, Mao

Mao Zedong fixes on ambitious plans to **industrialize China**.

In the **Great Leap Forward**, all Chinese society is **directed to this cause**.

Famine strikes, and mass starvation ensues. **Tens of millions die**.

Mao launches the Cultural Revolution.

Mao’s death marks a key turning point in China’s post-war history.

Deng Xiaoping’s adoption of **capitalist ideas** allows China to move toward **superpower status**.

decided to purge any opposition and transform capitalists and intellectuals into proletarians—ordinary workers. He ordered the Cultural Revolution, which would attack the “Four Olds”: old ideas, old habits, old customs, and old culture. Squads of young communists, incited by Mao and known as the Red Guards, terrorized intellectuals, bureaucrats, and teachers.